JPSG JOURNAL OF POLITICS, SOCIETY & GOVERNANCE

ISSN: XXXX-XXXX (PRINT)
ISSN: XXXX-XXXX (ONLINE)

Volume XX Issue X XXXXXXX 2027

Beyond the Heroic Narrative: Everyday Micro-Politics, Body Politics, and the Gendered Logistics of Resistance in the Nationalist and Revolutionary Movements of Andhra Pradesh

Priyanka Gangarapu *
Faculty of Political Science, Andhra University, Visakhapatnam, India
Email: priyaphd321@gmail.com

Isampalli Raghu Raja
M.A. Political Science, Andhra University, Visakhapatnam, India
Email: iraghuraja25@gmail.com

**Corresponding Author Email: priyaphd321@gmail.com*

Article DOI: https://doi.org/10.XXXXX/

Abstract: *Mainstream historiography of the Indian nationalist and revolutionary movements has predominantly documented elite political trajectories, frequently rendering the massive participation of grassroots women invisible. While women have historically fought against systemic patriarchy and colonial oppression to claim political rights—such as franchise and equal agency—their physical and biological realities within public and revolutionary spaces remain unaddressed. This paper examines the unheralded participation of women in the nationalist and revolutionary movements of Andhra Pradesh, bridging the gap between macro-political resistance and the everyday micro-politics of the female body. Drawing upon primary oral history testimonies of veteran freedom fighters and revolutionary leaders (such as Mallu Swarajyam, Choudary Sampurnamma, Bhoopathi Varalakshmi, and Bidika Mahalakshmamma), this study highlights the 'invisible logistics' of resistance—specifically, sanitation, public washroom accessibility, and menstrual management during guerrilla warfare and mass mobilizations. It argues that true political equality cannot be conceptualized without acknowledging and addressing the biological and structural barriers faced by women in public domains, and explores the paradox of post-independence political marginalization alongside the enduring socio-cultural legacy of these grassroots women.*

Keywords: Micro-Politics, Body Politics, Menstrual Hygiene, Grassroots Women, Nationalist Movement, Andhra Pradesh, Oral History, Post-Independence Marginalization

Introduction

Globally and historically, women have been relegated to the status of second-class citizens, constrained by systemic gender discrimination and patriarchal structures. Despite these barriers, women broke through domestic thresholds to participate in nationalist and revolutionary movements, earning voting rights and political representation. However, a critical dimension has been persistently ignored by mainstream political history: the intersection of political participation with biological realities. While male revolutionaries could navigate public spaces, protests, and underground guerrilla hideouts with relative bodily ease,

women faced an invisible layer of everyday struggle. This paper explores the unrecognized micro-politics of women's bodies in the freedom and revolutionary struggles of Andhra Pradesh, bringing forth oral testimonies that expose the harsh, unspoken realities of female resistance.

Objectives of the Study

- To document the unheralded participation and historical contributions of grassroots women in the nationalist and revolutionary movements of Andhra Pradesh.
- To explore the everyday micro-politics and body politics, specifically focusing on the physical challenges, menstrual hygiene management, and sanitation deficits faced by women in public and guerrilla spaces.
- To analyze the systemic and post-independence political marginalization of these women despite their foundational sacrifices.
- To evaluate the enduring socio-cultural legacy of these grassroots leaders in contemporary feminist and political discourse.

Hypothesis

The political participation of women in the nationalist and revolutionary movements of Andhra Pradesh was fundamentally shaped and constrained by biological realities and patriarchal structures, wherein their massive grassroots contributions were co-opted or rendered invisible by mainstream historical narratives, leading to their structural marginalization in post-independence political frameworks.

Methodology

This study adopts a historical-analytical and descriptive methodology to re-examine the role of women through a gendered lens. It relies heavily on primary sources, specifically utilizing oral history data gathered through direct interviews with veteran revolutionary figures such as Mallu Swarajyam (Telangana Armed Struggle), Choudary Sampurnamma and Bhoopathi Varalakshmi (Srikakulam Peasant Uprising), and Bidika Mahalakshmamma (Anti-Arrack Movement). Secondary sources include archival records, contemporary journals, autobiographies, and scholarly literature on gender and subaltern studies.

Body of the Article: Everyday Micro-Politics and Body Politics

History books record arrests, lathi-charges, and underground strategies of movements, but they rarely document the physical management of the female body under extreme revolutionary conditions. Insights gathered from primary oral history interviews with prominent women leaders who shaped the history of Andhra Pradesh reveal profound realities:

Menstrual Management in Guerrilla Warfare: Veteran leader Mallu Swarajyam, during her interviews regarding the Telangana Armed Struggle, highlighted the extreme hardships women faced during menstruation while operating in deep forests. In the absence of basic sanitary facilities, women had to resort to using leaves, improvising with men's towels, or sitting silently in the sand, managing excruciating pain while evading police and landlords. Similar harrowing experiences were echoed by leaders like Choudary Sampurnamma and Bhoopathi Varalakshmi during the Srikakulam peasant struggles, and Bidika Mahalakshmamma during the anti-arrack movement.

The Stigma of the Female Body: When movement participants experienced unexpected bleeding or physical stains during public rallies or marches, instead of receiving empathy, they often faced harsh social judgment, ridicule, and patriarchal surveillance. This created a dual burden: fighting the state or oppressor on one front, and constantly managing the stigma of the biological body on another.

Sanitation and Infrastructure Deficits: From historical protests to contemporary political rallies, the lack of basic gender-segregated sanitation and washroom facilities continues to be a major deterrent for women. This structural neglect restricts women's spontaneous and uninhibited participation in public life.

Discussion

The narratives extracted from oral testimonies challenge the sanitized and romanticized versions of political revolutions. By bringing concepts of 'body politics' and 'invisible logistics' into historical analysis, this study demonstrates that political resistance is not gender-neutral. The failure of mainstream historiography to account for biological constraints reflects a broader patriarchal bias within institutional politics. Furthermore, the transition from active revolutionary mobilization to post-independence governance highlights a severe political paradox: while

women were mobilized as foot soldiers during crises, actual decision-making power remained concentrated within elite male-dominated structures. This discussion underscores the necessity of rewriting subaltern history through an embodied, gender-conscious framework.

Conclusion

The history of the nationalist and revolutionary movements in Andhra Pradesh remains incomplete without acknowledging the gendered logistics of survival. Women's participation was not merely ideological; it was deeply physical, negotiated through every drop of blood, every sanitary compromise in the forests, and every struggle against domestic and public patriarchy. Recognizing these micro-politics is essential for redefining democratic spaces, ensuring that political participation is truly inclusive of biological and social realities, and restoring the rightful place of grassroots women in historical memory.

References

Godavari Perulekar (2008), "*Warli Aadivasi Tirugubatu"*, prajasakthi Book house, Hyderabad.

Sundarayya Puchalapalli (ed.) (2016), "*Veera Telangana Porata Gadhalu*", Nava Telangana Publishing House, Hyderabad.

Mallu Swarajyam (2020), "*Nagonthe Thupaki Toota", Navatelangana Publication, Hyderabad.*

Interviews

Choudary Sampoornamma

Bhupathi Varalaxmi

Mallu Swarajyam (Telephone)

Biddika Mahalaxmamma